

BITS O' BASEBALL . . . By Johnny Carrico

This is the last in a series analyzing the American Association teams.

HOLLYWOOD, Fla., April 6.—From a winging first place in 1956 to a stumbling eighth this season might very well be the miserable lot of Indianapolis. What wrought such a drastic change? Merely the not so simple loss of a valuable connection with Cleveland.

The Indians—big Indians, that is—put a top-grade outfit in the Hoosier capital last year, with such potential stars as Larry Raines, Roger Maris, John Gray, Russ Nixon, Stan Pitula and others. But Indianapolis and Hank Greenberg, the Cleveland chief of staff, got into a hassle over the disposition of Rocky Colavito and the ties were severed.

Indianapolis is working this year with the Chicago White Sox, not nearly as profitable a connection. The Sox have very few Triple-A players in their cupboard, which prompted a Hoosier official to remark gloomily, "We may be playing Triple-A competition this year with a Double-A club that finished second." He referred to Memphis, a Chicago vassal, which may furnish most of the troops.

Romano, Hairston Are Catchers

New manager Andy Cohen, promoted from New Orleans where he finished fifth, steps into a forbidding post. However, he may have the consolation that Indianapolis fans may be accustomed to drastic runs up and down the Association ladder. Last year the Hoosiers won, the year before they were seventh, 24½ games out of first.

Amid all the uncertainties of his personnel, Cohen probably can count one position as set—



Greenberg



Tony Ponce



Ron Northey

From The Top to Bottom Could Be The Story Of Tribeless Indianapolis

catching. John Romano, .241 with Vancouver last season, will be the first-string receiver. His relief will be Sam Hairston, a 31-year-old husky who rattled .318 for Colorado Springs.

The severance of the bonds with Cleveland practically drained the Indianapolis roster, leaving only two players. One of them is seasoned George Spencer, a pitcher; the other is aging Ted Beard, a 35-year-old outfielder.

Spencer, a reliever, had a 5-4 record and a 4.95 E.R.A. last year. The Hoosiers may have one of the oldest staffs in the A.A. with such graybeards as Tony Ponce, Al Papai and Charley Bicknell. The 36-year-old Ponce tossed the opener for Louisville last year and wrote an 8-7 season record. Papai, despite his 37 years, notched 20 wins for the Chicks; Bicknell came to the Hoosiers in a trade with Atlanta for Paul Stuffer.

The most promising of the rookie throwers is 20-year-old Barry Latman, 14-14 at Memphis. Others who may stick are Rodolfo Arias (8-5 at Colorado Springs), Arnie Atkins (13-6 at San Diego) and Glen Rosenbaum (15-5 at Waterloo). On the borderline are Robert Hall (4-5 at San Diego), Richard Atkinson (7-10 at Sioux City) and Al Pawelek (a free agent).

First base is a tender spot. The Hoosiers hope to get Norm Larker from the White Sox, but St. Paul hasn't given up hope that he will return to them. If Larker doesn't show, it will be Jim Marshall. Don Mincher is running the position now until help arrives.

The purchase of Vinicio "Chico" Garcia from Wichita solved the problem of second base while shortstop likely will be manned by a rookie optioned from Chicago, 22-year-old Don Prohovich. The Ware, Mass., youngster, signed off the Holy Cross campus last year, hit 11 homers and .284 in 71 games with Colorado Springs.

The Hoosiers need a third sacker. At present it's Ed Taylor, signed as a free agent, but he's on the doubtful list. Charley Williams, .278 with Nashville, will serve as utility man.

The outfield will need strengthening. Beard and veteran Jim Delsing, when and if he signs, figure to be two thirds of it. Richard Means (.244 with Colorado Springs), will be kept. If help comes from the Chisox, it could be Ron Northey, a part-timer in Hoosier-land last year and Jim Landis, an N.D.S. player.